Muzaffar Khan chose exile.

As part of the deal, he also released an old prisoner. Sharafuddin, the emperor's former brother-in-law, languishing in chains ever since he was handed over to Akbar in Gujarat, was blessed with many lives and a stubborn spirit. A string of failed alliances had landed him in Akbar's dungeons, but when Sharafuddin walked out of Tanda a free man, he promptly joined the Qaqshals.

Whether at the tireless old rebel's suggestion, or from their own unabated resentment, it was on the day after Sharafuddin's release that the mutineers broke their promise to Muzaffar Khan. Instead of letting the governor go, they stormed Tanda and began to plunder. Muzaffar Khan, out to save money till the end, managed to sink eight chests full of gold in a nearby lake. But his luck had run dry. Sharafuddin found the chests, took the gold, and replaced it with stones. Muzaffar Khan, meanwhile, was imprisoned, along with Abul Fath and Rai Patr Das. These two, regardless of Badauni's low opinion of them, had the wits to escape. Or perhaps the rebels weren't watching over them with much care; it was Muzaffar Khan they were after. The irascible accountant, so happy these past few years in the glow of Akbar's favour, had shown as much skill in battle as with his ledgers, but none, in the end, for governance. He was so hated that the rebels put him through 'all sorts of tortures', writes Badauni, as they killed him.

On 22 May, four months after the Qaqshals began their revolt and a month after they killed Akbar's governor, the chiefs of Bengal held a grand assembly, at which they gave themselves titles and land – and a new king. They read the khutba in Mirza Muhammad Hakim's name.

~

A terrible 'Divine wrath', writes Abul Fazl, descended upon the rebels' party. A great storm 'scattered' their tent, flinging their carpets 'into the mire' as the 'wretches . . . crept away'. For all the loyal indignation of his scribe, however, Akbar may have taken the matter far more in his stride. In fact, he had anticipated it. When news of the rebellion first arrived, the emperor had declared that he would not hurry east to suppress it. The rebels' 'audacity . . . is being backed . . . by the ruler of Kabul', he had said. 'It is not unlikely that flatterers may bring that light-headed, evil-thinking one into [Hindustan].' Akbar decided to wait and watch; and he was proven